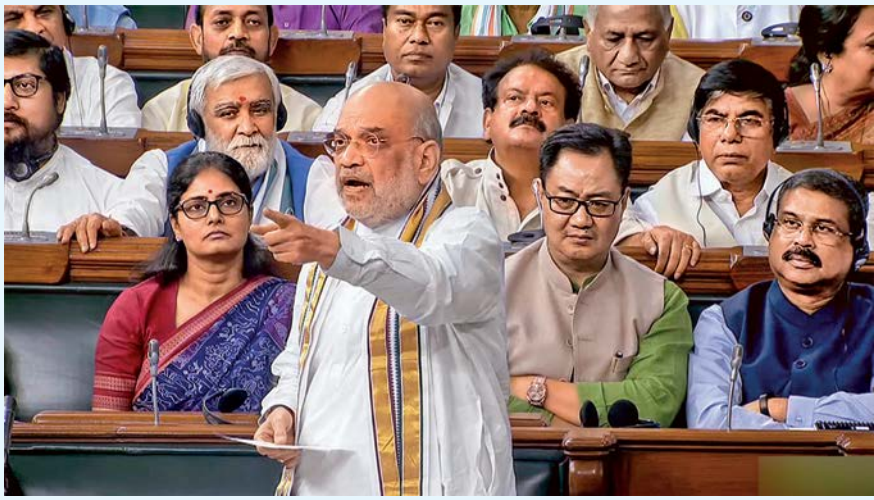
For instance, the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023, comes as a pioneering law on data privacy, but critics say it gives enough exemptions to the government to mount surveillance on citizens by bullying big tech companies.

The Forest (Conservation) Amendment Act, 2023, was another source of discord. It came under heavy fire from environmentalists who said it empowers the Centre to potentially sell, divert and exploit forest areas without any regulatory oversight. The government admits the amendment exempts certain categories of lands from the purview of the Act, but stresses it is only meant to fast-track projects of national importance. Besides, it claims the Act has new provisions to boost India's forest cover.

The Indian Institutes of Management (Amendment) Act, 2023, also came under heavy scrutiny, with detractors saying it's an assault on the autonomy of these prestigious institutes as the government has now expanded its role on appointment of directors. In fact, the amended law restores to the government powers it had ceded to the IIMs in 2017 through the Indian Institutes of Management (IIM) Act. Government sources allege the IIMs have had a "governance vacuum" in the past six years. They cite how the earlier Act required the board of governors of IIMs to commission an independent review of the institutes once in three years and place the report in the public domain. Even among the top four, only one has followed this practice.

Amid the fractious notes, the session also saw legislations that received unanimous support. For instance, the Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Act, 2023, which decriminalised 183 provisions in 42 central acts, and the Cinematograph (Amendment) Act, 2023, which aims to deter film piracy with strict penalties. Parliament also passed the Anusandhan National Research Foundation Act, 2023, intended to foster and universalise a culture of research and innovation by putting up the capital required for it and spreading it more evenly. Funds for R&D, already scarce, tended to be monopolised by prestigious centres, leaving state-level educational and research institutes high and dry. A Rs 50,000 crore fund proposes to remedy this, although there are concerns that private sector involvement can steer research towards utilitarian rather than foundational ends.

On the political front, there was a big development—the return of Rahul Gandhi. On March 24, in the middle of the budget session, the Congress leader had been disqualified after a Gujarat court awarded him two years' imprisonment in a defamation case—the maximum possible sentence in such cases. By an odd coincidence, that was also the minimum required to automatically strip a lawmaker of his or her membership in a legislative house. Rahul had thus ceased to be the Lok Sabha MP from Wayanad in Kerala.



ANI

THE COUNTER Union home minister Amit Shah in the Lok Sabha

Change-making Legislations

Amid sloganeering and adjournments, the monsoon session passed several significant laws

INTER-SERVICES ORGANISATIONS (COMMAND, CONTROL AND DISCIPLINE) ACT, 2023
Empowers heads of inter-services bodies to exercise effective command over personnel of the Indian air force, army, navy and persons of other allied forces attached to it

THE DIGITAL PERSONAL DATA PROTECTION ACT, 2023
Establishes a comprehensive framework for protection of personal data of citizens. It extends its jurisdiction to personal data, both online and offline, collected within India, that has been digitised. It sets out requirements for firms collecting data online, with exceptions for government and law enforcement agencies

THE GOVERNMENT OF NATIONAL CAPITAL TERRITORY OF DELHI (AMENDMENT) ACT, 2023
Establishes the Centre's primacy in appointments, transfers and postings of officers in the national capital of Delhi

The effect of a clutch of contentious bills may prove more long-lasting than a no-trust vote or Rahul Gandhi's return